THIRTEEN

When the postings had been disclosed, Assey Sir told me that I was being posted to one of the best stations and that I would be exposed to a variety of opportunities. After a break of three weeks, which I spent first in Delhi with my college friends and then at home in Lucknow, I headed back to Jammu, where an army convoy was waiting to take me to the Udhampur military station.

The Indian Air Force station at Udhampur was a long distance from the convoy grounds, so Flight Lieutenant Tony, who was the adjutant of my unit, had come with a Gypsy to receive me. Where I was expecting a warm welcome from my unit officer, all he said was, ‘Welcome to the unit, Gunjan. Put your stuff in this Gypsy and reach the officers’ mess.’ After this he sat on his motorcycle and drove away. The unit did not have an independent mess and there was a common officers’ mess in the air force station. Upon reaching, I met the mess manager, who told me that Srividya, my course mate who was also posted to the same unit, and I would be sharing a room on the first floor. It was a set of two rooms with a small balcony. A mess boy was assigned to us as our helper.

Srividya, a tall, lean girl, reached in the evening and we helped each other settle down. Though we hadn’t talked much with each other during training, we got along quickly in no time. When we finally went outside into the beautiful garden at the mess, we could see the entire city of